



New VP for Tesla autopilot

Tesla's new vice president for their autopilot software is Chris Lattner, formerly of Apple and creator of Swift. <http://digit.in/VPtesla>



Malaria diagnosing light

Matibabu is a technology that uses light and magnetism to analyse your blood for signs of malaria infection. <http://digit.in/maibabu>

Origins

While it outdid its predecessor in Edison's invention and was also displayed at the World Fair in Paris in 1900, the American Telegraphone Company, which was supposed to make the telegraphones under license in the US, failed to ever actually manufacture the device for the market and hence it got



A blind stenographer using the dictaphone

very little chance to be popularly used.

It was closer to the first World War that the Dictaphone Corporation released a new device capable of recording from telephone lines. It was quite effective, to the point that AT&T had to ban its use on public lines. Much of the reputation of detectives and spies around that time came from portable recording devices like the Dictaphone or Dictagraph. Around this time, the preventive activities of one William J. Burns, also known as 'America's Sherlock Holmes', with the dictograph were quite influential in convincing the public that, "even the walls had ears". The days of the wiretap wouldn't end anytime soon, but the world was moving towards a more invasive method of surveillance – eavesdropping.

Eavesdropping

The word conjures the image of ears laid on closed doors or under open windows. Post the first World War, the general public had never really recov-

ered from their paranoia and suspicion that a third man was listening to their conversations. Microphones were by then sufficiently small to be concealed effectively among everyday objects. By the time an unfortunate series of events had led the world to another World War, technology was



Spying of this nature is more common in government activities

advanced enough for 'bugging' and 'wearing a wire' to be commonplace fears, and capture systems could play back recorded audio without the need for processing.

By the 1950s, these recording devices would have reached such a level of miniaturisation that they could be concealed on a person, along with the power source and transmitter. Transmitters would, in turn, relay the audio to a nearby receiver where a third party would be listening in on the conversations/audio from the mic. In fact, such devices were being popularly used in television shows and detective work already. A brief idea of the popularity of these devices can be gleaned from the admission of a particular firm to have installed 4000 such devices in the Washington DC area of United States alone.

The peeping tom

While audio surveillance was the only dominant form of surveillance for nearly 50 years, as with everything

in the world of technology, that was to change soon. The size and the bulk associated with cameras over the years had led the general public to believe that cameras couldn't really be concealed. Hence, miniaturisation itself paved the path for cameras to be perfect 'spying devices' for a long time. In fact, even in the first half of the 1900s, there were quite a few models like the Micro 16 and the Petal Camera that were popularly used for concealed photography. The Petal was even one of the smallest cameras ever made, at the size of the American Quarter. Another unique camera that stood the test of time in its own era was the Steineck ABC Wrist Watch Camera which, as you must have guessed by now, looked like a wristwatch and no, it didn't tell the time. And no article about early spy cameras would be complete without mentioning the Minox series of cameras that were a spy staple for over three decades till the 1960s. And mind you, getting any one of these at their launch would set you back by almost a week's pay.

What the steam engine did to the manufacturing sector, video surveillance did to the surveillance industry. As early as 1965, there were supposed reports of surveillance cameras being used in the United States. Pretty soon, it was evident that the police were using surveillance cameras in places of interest to monitor public activity and look for signs of trouble. The next big push was when video cassette recorders hit the market. The seventies



Closed Circuit TV (CCTV) cameras have grown to be ubiquitous